Country Profile: Belarus

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Belarusian Orthodox
- Official language: Belarussian, Russian
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Belarusians

Historical Background

The Byelorussian Soviet Socialist Republic (SSR) declared its sovereignty in 1990 and changed its name to the Republic of Belarus. The USSR officially dissolved in 1991, which the NBP dataset considers as the start date for all post-Soviet republics, including Belarus.

Groups

- **Belarusians** are the core ethnic group in Belarus, making up 85% of the population.[1] Although Belarusian is their ancestral language, many now speak Russian due to its widespread use in education and daily life, and the limited promotion of Belarusian. The Belarusian Orthodox Church, an exarchate of the Russian Orthodox Church, is the main religion among them. A significant proportion of Belarusians today identify as non-religious, and there is also a small Roman Catholic community in the western part of the country, influenced by historical connections with Poland and Lithuania.[2]

- **Russians** are the largest minority group in Belarus, comprising 7.5% of the total population.[3] Despite their relatively small numbers, the Russian language and the Russian Orthodox Church play a dominant role in the country. This prominence reflects the long history of Belarus's ties with Russia, including its time under the Russian Empire and the USSR.

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[1] National Statistical Committee of the Republic of Belarus, 2020.
[2] Joshua Project, 2024.
[3] Belarus, 2020.

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- **Poles** make up 3% of the population in Belarus and are mainly concentrated in the Grodno region.[4] Their presence in Belarus is rooted in centuries of Polish-Russian conflict over dominance in East-Central Europe. Polish remains a key part of their identity, though it is the first language of only 16% of Poles in Belarus. Meanwhile, 67% identify Belarusian and 16% identify Russian as their native languages.[5] The majority of Poles are Roman Catholic, which is a central aspect of their cultural identity.[6]
- **Ukrainians** in Belarus are primarily descendants of migrants from Ukraine, reflecting the historical connections from when both were part of the same states, including the Russian Empire and the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth. The last major wave of Ukrainian immigrants arrived during the Soviet era.[7] Today, Ukrainians make up 1.7% of the population, with notable concentrations in Minsk and the Brest region.[8] Linguistically, there is a near-equal split between those who consider Russian and those who consider Ukrainian as their native language.[9] While many Ukrainians are non-religious, the majority adhere to Eastern Orthodox Christianity and attend the Belarusian Orthodox Church.

State Profile

Official Language

The first Constitution of independent Belarus, adopted in 1994, designated Belarusian as the state language and Russian as the language of interethnic communication. Following a 1995 referendum, Russian was granted the status of an official language alongside Belarusian, with the Constitutional amendments taking effect in 1996.[10]

Official Religion

The 1994 Constitution of Belarus explicitly prohibits any religion from becoming a state religion. Article 4 states, "The ideology of political parties, religious or other public associations, social groups cannot be established as mandatory for citizens," while

[4] Minority rights, 2015; Belarus, 2020.
[5] Belarus, 2020.
[6] Joshua project, 2024.
[7] Minority Rights, 2015.
[8] National Statistical Committee of the Republic of Belarus, 2020.
[9] Ethnologue, 2024.
[10] *Конституция Республики Беларусь / Редакция 24 ноября 1996 года.*

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ensuring religious freedom for all regardless of belief. The 2002 Law on Freedom of Conscience and Religious Organizations acknowledges the historical role of the Orthodox Church in Belarusian history. It also recognizes the significance of the Catholic Church and affirms the contributions of the Evangelical Lutheran Church, Judaism, and Islam to the general history of Belarus.[11]

Education Policies

Belarus regained its independence from the Soviet Union in 1991. Leading up to this, the Belarusian national movement advocated for cultural changes. In December 1990, the Language Act was passed, making Belarusian the sole official language.[12] Significant state reforms were introduced to democratize education and remove Marxist-Leninist content from the social sciences. New curricula and textbooks aimed to de-ideologize history and emphasize national history and democratic values. These reforms allowed for the establishment of private schools, including those operated by minorities in their national languages.[13]

However, by the late 1990s, President Lukashenko halted these reforms, arguing they promoted nationalism. The Belarusian education system still retains strong influences from Soviet traditions. Basic education includes a 4-year primary school followed by a 5-year lower secondary school, meeting compulsory education requirements. Article 49 of the 1994 Constitution guarantees free general and vocational education. The Law on the Education System, first enacted in 1991 and revised on March 19, 2002, ensures the secular nature of education among other principles.[14]

Language Education Policies

During the Soviet period, **Russian** was the dominant language in the educational system of the Byelorussian SSR. The wide network of Russian-language schools continued to operate after the independence of the country, ensuring the use of Russian as both the language of instruction and a language class.

The adoption of the Language Act in 1990 made **Belarusian** the sole official language of the educational system, establishing a foundation for its promotion. However, these

[11] *Закон Республики Беларусь. 2002. О свободе совести и религиозных организаций.*
[12] Belarus, 1990.
[13] Malerius, 2015
[14] Belarus, 2002.

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efforts were soon halted by the results of a 1995 referendum, which declared Russian as the second official language of Belarus, giving it equal status with Belarusian.[15] This change was formalized in the changes to the Language Act in 1998, which added Russian as a language of instruction in the country and a mandatory language class through the country.[16]

This resulted in a decline in the use of Belarusian as the language of instruction. By the 1995/1996 academic year, only 19.5% of grade 1 pupils in Minsk were in Belarusian-language schools, and this percentage continued to drop, falling to just 3.8% by 2001/2002. Although a higher proportion of pupils in rural areas attended Belarusian-language classes, the overall trend in both urban and rural areas showed a continued decline in the use of Belarusian in education.

As for other languages of instruction, they are not *de facto* present in the public educational system. However, Article 5 of the Educational Act on Languages of Instruction explicitly allows the establishment of such schools "in accordance with statements of the legal representatives of children and by decision of local executive and administrative bodies."[17] Article 21 of the 1990 Language Act also guarantees the rights of minorities to study their national language and use it as a language of instruction. Most of the minority schools are private. For example, there are two **Polish** schools in Grodno and Volkovynsk. Recently, the Ministry of Education of Belarus approved the curriculum of extracurricular activities in the **Ukrainian** language for secondary schools with Belarusian and Russian languages of instruction.[18]

Religious Education Policies

The Education Act of Belarus mandates secular education as a core principle, further supported by the Law on the Freedom of Conscience and Religious Organizations. Only Russian Orthodoxy is integrated into the public education system as an optional subject, "Fundamentals of Orthodox Culture: Orthodox Shrines of the Eastern Slavs," introduced in 2010.[19] Registered religious organizations are permitted to establish private schools.

[15] SB.BY., 1995.
[16] Belarus, 1990.
[17] Belarus, 2002.
[18] Наша Ніва, 2018.
[19] *Официальный портал Белорусской Православной Церкви, 2024.*

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Bans and Restrictions

Belarusian language laws support Russian-Belarusian bilingualism, restricting other languages in official naming. The 1998 Language Act amendments mandate that state bodies, local authorities, enterprises, public associations, toponyms, and maps use Belarusian and/or Russian, allowing translations if needed. Personal names and surnames must adhere to Belarusian and/or Russian norms, with foreign names transcribed accordingly.

Constitutions and Laws

In 1990, the Byelorussian SSR declared its legal sovereignty from the USSR through the Declaration of State Sovereignty, giving its laws legal priority over USSR laws. This marked the beginning of Belarus's constitutional process. Subsequently, on August 25, 1991, a special law elevated the Declaration of State Sovereignty to the status of constitutional law, leading to amendments and additions to the 1978 Constitution of the Byelorussian SSR. Formally speaking, the 1978 Constitution of the Byelorussian SSR, with amendments, was in force in the period 1991–1993. The original constitution did not include formal provisions on the state language, although the 1990 Language Act had declared Belarusian as the state language. It also lacked mention of specific groups but contained several provisions on religious liberty. The 1994 Constitution's first edition confirmed Belarusian as the sole state language and reinforced religious freedoms and the principles of a secular state in education and public affairs. The 1996 amendments established Russian as a co-official language and significantly increased presidential powers. Subsequently, the Belarusian Constitution has been amended several times to legitimize the presidency of Alexander Lukashenko.

Citizenship Laws

On November 12, 1991, Belarus enacted a new citizenship law granting citizenship to all individuals permanently residing in the country at the time of independence. As the Soviet Union dissolved, citizens of the Byelorussian SSR with permanent residency in other Soviet republics acquired citizenship there, often inadvertently, while USSR citizens permanently residing in Belarus automatically became Belarusian citizens. Although the 1991 law resolved the citizenship status for many, it left those Byelorussian SSR citizens who did not have permanent residence in Belarus at the time of independence without citizenship.

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The 2002 Citizenship Law introduced a simplified procedure for acquiring citizenship, including a form of conditional *ius soli* citizenship for foreigners. According to Article 13, a child born in Belarus to parents (or a single parent) who are permanent residents of Belarus but hold foreign citizenship can acquire Belarusian citizenship if their country of origin does not grant citizenship by descent.

Citizenship legislation in Belarus includes special language and country-based provisions for naturalization. The 1991 Citizenship Law initially required knowledge of the Belarusian language. This requirement was amended in 1996 to allow knowledge of either Belarusian or Russian. Additionally, Belarus has established simplified naturalization procedures through bilateral agreements with Russia (1999), Kazakhstan (1998), Kyrgyzstan (1999), and Ukraine (2000).

National Anthem(s)

Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991, Belarus retained the anthem that had been used by the Byelorussian SSR since 1955, though the lyrics were removed. In 2002, new lyrics were added to the national anthem, written by Uladzimir Karyzna. These lyrics, based on the Soviet Republic's anthem and closely mirroring those of the Byelorussian SSR's anthem, are officially titled "Мы, беларусы" [We Are Belarusians] and are available in Belarusian. The lyrics contain ambiguous references to Belarussian nationhood and military imagery, celebrate heroic deeds from the past, and reference the national territory.

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